

## S05-03 - Holding the Line

### Player text

The skeletons come in a clatter of rust and bone: not clever, but endless, and all of them reaching for the glowing figure at the center. For every one you put down, the ritual's clock ticks a notch closer to done. But they keep clawing up out of the dirt, and the Custodian cannot defend herself. The line is yours to hold.

### Public objective

Defeat the rusted dead and keep the Custodian safe.

### Raw source

- Id: S05-03
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-FIVE
- Sectiontitle: Act Five: The Ward Renewal
- Title: Holding the Line
- Shorttitle: Skeletons
- Order: 603
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png
- Alt: The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal.
- Caption: Holding the line teaches that defeating pressure and protecting the center are the same victory.
- Mood: The Ward Renewal
- Gmgoal: Run the rusted-sword skeleton wave as clear protection pressure and countdown progress.
- Publicobjective: Defeat the rusted dead and keep the Custodian safe.
- Readaloud: The skeletons come in a clatter of rust and bone: not clever, but endless, and all of them reaching for the glowing figure at the center. For every one you put down, the ritual's clock ticks a notch closer to done. But they keep clawing up out of the dirt, and the Custodian cannot defend herself. The line is yours to hold.
- Gmnotes: Skeletons are pressure and countdown fuel, not a slog. Keep them moving toward the Custodian.
- Gmscript: Say: "They are not strong. They are persistent, and they want her, not you. Stand in the way. Every one you drop moves the countdown down by one."
- Gmreadaloud: The skeletons come in a clatter of rust and bone. All of them reach for the glowing figure at the center. The line is yours to hold.
- Gmchecklist: Use Legacy Skeleton stats: Difficulty 12, HP 2, Stress 1, ATK +0, Rusted Sword 1d6+1 physical. Damage 6 or less marks 1 HP; above that defeats the skeleton. Each defeat ticks ritual\_countdown -1. Spend Fear for Group Attack when skeletons cluster: one shared +0 roll, 4 physical per skeleton combined. Track who body-blocks the Custodian as protected\_whom seed.

- Gmprivate: Name them Legacy Skeletons only after the table has the image. Corporate-asset undertone stays GM-side.
- Playertakeaway: Hold the perimeter; every skeleton you drop is a step toward the end.
- Storytakeaway: The first wave is beatable, but it never stops reaching for her.
- Mechanictakeaway: Skeleton defeats tick the countdown down, but Group Attack spikes damage if the party lets them cluster.
- Rollcards: s05-03-shield-the-custodian S05-03 Shield the Custodian Shield the Custodian Agility Strength Agility Strength 13 Agility intercepts; Strength holds the line. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual countdown ticks the wrong way. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time, noise, leverage, or a visible resource. The result lands...
- Entityids: whitefire-custodian keystone-asset ritual-countdown legacy-security-skeleton the-stones-of-the-vale the-miremist moonglow open-valetm-ritual-site goldspire-territories sablewoodtm-logistics-preserve eeligator-scale-shield soul-audit-wraith eeligator damage-armor fear ward-moths sunfire-lily mist-things
- Entities: whitefire-custodian Whitefire Custodian npc NPC / Ally assets/icons/npc.png assets/npc-images/whitefire-custodian/portrait\_base.png WHITE-fire kus-TOH-dee-un Old faerie-like custodian who maintains the ward protecting Hush. Truth-bearer for the Keystone reveal. Whitefire Custodian an old faerie-like ward keeper whose exhaustion glows around the edges Ancient kindness running on fumes, glowing a little brighter whenever someone tells the truth nearby. Wants to keep one place honestly safe long enough for people to remember that safety can be care instead of a product, and is quietly breaking under the cost of it. Renew the ward without being treated as a device. Please do not call me the ward interface. an old faerie-like ward keeper whose exhaustion glows around the edges npc-profile-v1 NPC\_System\_Packet + image-informed hardening Whitefire Custodian an old faerie-like ward keeper whose exhaustion glows around the edges A tall luminous faerie custodian stands like living bark and white fire, branchlike crown, translucent wings, and warm gold light gathered in the chest. Whitefire Custodian: an old faerie-like ward keeper whose exhaustion glows around the edges Whitefire...
- Locationids: open-valetm-ritual-site goldspire-territories sablewoodtm-logistics-preserve the-miremist the-stones-of-the-vale
- Itemids: eeligator-scale-shield
- Clueids: glass-bright-ward-sand
- Statecontrols: ward\_stability Ward Stability select fragile stable ritual\_prep Ritual Prep select unready ready keystone\_understanding Keystone Understanding select surface deep ritual\_countdown Ritual Countdown number 10 8 ritual\_outcome

Ritual Outcome select unresolved clean costly pyrrhic protected\_whom Protected Whom  
 select unresolved custodian party hush shared custodian\_fate Custodian Fate select  
 unresolved well drained dying strixwolf\_disposition Strixwolf Disposition select  
 unresolved calm hostile killed strixwolf\_outcome Strixwolf Outcome select unresolved  
 calmed helped avoided attacked killed strixwolf\_trust Strixwolf Trust number 3  
 strixwolf\_blood\_debt Strixwolf Blood Debt checkbox bramble\_outcome Bramble Outcome  
 select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated escaped let\_cargo  
 bramble\_truth\_learned Bramble Truth Learned checkbox package\_status Package Status  
 select held lost hush\_trust Hush Trust select low neutral high custodian\_route  
 Custodian Route select unknown safe dangerous ward\_awareness Ward Awareness select  
 none seed aware festival\_boon Festival Boon select none charm favor market\_find  
 goodwill custodian\_trust Custodian Trust select low neutral high hush\_clues Hush...

- Mechanicids: countdown adversary-spotlight adversary-attacks damage-rolls evasion  
 damage-thresholds vulnerable fear group-attack action-roll
- Playerquestions: Who puts themselves between the dead and the Custodian? Who calls  
 out a clustering danger? Who drives the countdown down?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees  
 about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in The Ritual Begins that belongs to your  
 character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate  
 ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong  
 direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory  
 Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Choicesconsequences: Drop a skeleton. One pressure body falls. Tick ritual\_countdown  
 -1. The party sees progress and the ward flashes stronger. ritual\_countdown -1  
 Reward: visible progress. player-visible Body-block the Custodian. A skeleton cannot  
 reach the center. May prevent a +1 tick without a roll if position is clear;  
 otherwise Agility/Strength vs risk. protected\_whom records who held the line.  
 protected\_whom=custodian/shared Reward: safer center, possible personal cost.  
 player-visible Let skeletons cluster. The wave becomes a single heavy hit. GM may  
 spend Fear for Group Attack. Damage and stress force harder choices in S05-04/05.  
 fear spent; protected\_whom pressure Penalty: spike damage. player-visible
- Lootclues: Ritual Countdown table Open Vale residue after completion Eeligator Scale  
 Shield: A round shield of overlapping slick green-grey scales catches the light like  
 river-water. It smells of deep water, mud, and old teeth.
- Handoutids: Ritual countdown Guaranteed seed
- Sourcescenelug: S05-03-the-ritual-begins
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act5\_Upgrade\_Packet/ACT5\_SCENE\_RESEARCH.md  
 dist/Act5\_Upgrade\_Packet/ACT5\_MAPS\_AND\_LOCATIONS.md
- References: Holding line map #MAP-S05-03 Peak battle map #MAP-COMBAT-S05-05
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie  
 about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it  
 by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the  
 danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Soul-Audit Wraiths bear  
 audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."  
 REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-  
 credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest

creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and name Soulsfire without the GM naming it first. ADD EARNED Knowledge Medium 15 Optional flag: Legacy Skeletons carry scraps of old corporate credentials. FLAG SEED Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit." REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Instinct: target logic. Knowledge: read markings. ACT5 Act 5: Open Vale defense 200 2:40 to 3:20 3:20 countdown 8, skeletons, wraiths, Market Correction Lower the countdown start to 6; cap wraith reinforcements.

- Livetools: encounter S05-03 MAP-S05-03 pages/combat/s05-03.html
- Percharacterlayer: khari-nix Khari Nix Guardian line Built to hold a chokepoint and keep multiple skeletons off the Custodian. Can body-block several skeletons or break a cluster. Khari, this is what a Guardian is for. Want to hold the line and keep them off her? garrick-reed Garrick Reed Hit them hard Can one-shot fragile skeletons and drive the countdown down. A clean Warrior hit can become visible clock progress. Garrick, these things pop in one solid hit. Want to drive the countdown down? varian-soto Varian Soto Deadly aim Can pick off skeletons before they reach the center. Controls the perimeter from range. Varian, you can drop them before they close. Want to thin the wave? barnacle Barnacle Safety net Can flit to whoever is exposed and disrupt a cluster. Can prevent Group Attack or protect a soft lane. Barnacle, you can flit to whoever is exposed. Want to be the party's safety net? marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Break the rule Can see the old pattern animating the bones. Knowledge 13 Neutralizes one pressure point without pure damage, still ticking the countdown if it truly removes threat. Can show that understanding counts as progress. Marlowe, the bones are following a rule. Want to...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway Hold the perimeter; every skeleton you drop is a step toward the end. "Cut them down, keep them off her, watch the clock fall. This part you can win with grit." "Position between the dead and the Custodian, strike the nearest, and call out if they start to swarm." Keep the first combat wave empowering before the wraiths complicate it. countdown fear group-attack evasion Story takeaway The first wave is beatable, but it never stops reaching for her. "They are not strong; they are persistent, and they want her, not you." "Describe them as rusted-sword dead first. If players ask later, the GM term is Legacy Skeletons." The corporate-asset undertone stays GM-side unless earned. countdown fear group-attack evasion Mechanic takeaway Skeleton defeats tick the countdown down, but Group Attack spikes damage if the party lets them cluster. "Squishy alone. Hit one hard enough and it is gone; clock ticks down. Let them cluster and I can spend Fear for one ugly combined hit." "Difficulty 12, HP 2, 1d6+1 physical. Group Attack is one +0 roll, 4 physical per skeleton combined." Use Group Attack as warning/payoff for ignored clusters, not surprise punishment. countdown fear...
- Playerbeats: s05-03-clatter Clatter The clatter assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal. Rusted dead claw up in a clatter of bone and metal, all of them reaching for the center. Rusted dead claw up in a clatter of bone and metal, all of them reaching for the center. Rusted dead claw up in a clatter of bone and metal, all of them reaching for the center. text-first s05-03-line Line Hold the line assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal. Stand between the dead and the Custodian, split their clusters, and keep them off the center. Stand between the dead and the Custodian, split their clusters, and keep them off the center. Stand

between the dead and the Custodian, split their clusters, and keep them off the center. text-first s05-03-clock Clock The clock falls assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal. Every skeleton defeated or truly neutralized moves the countdown one step closer to zero. Every skeleton defeated or truly neutralized moves the countdown one step closer to zero. Every skeleton defeated or truly neutralized moves the countdown...

- Gmbeats: s05-03-clatter Clatter The clatter Say: "They are not clever. They are relentless." Rusted dead claw up in a clatter of bone and metal, all of them reaching for the center. The first pressure is physical and readable. Simple adversaries teach countdown rhythm. Players understand the first wave. Player takeaway Players understand the first wave. "They are not clever. They are relentless." "The table-facing answer is: Players understand the first wave." Use this beat to give the players one visible next action: protect the center, read the field, spend prep, name who they shield, or choose what truth leaves with them. countdown Story takeaway The first pressure is physical and readable. "They are not clever. They are relentless." "The story answer is: The first pressure is physical and readable." Tie the answer to a visible Act 5 consequence: the ward steadies, the Custodian suffers, Hush is protected, or the final report changes who owns the truth. countdown Mechanic takeaway Simple adversaries teach countdown rhythm. "They are not clever. They are relentless." "The active table procedure is: Simple adversaries teach countdown rhythm." Name intent first. Use a Daggerheart roll...
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 8000
- Playersafeprojection: S05-03 scene Holding the Line assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal. Holding the line teaches that defeating pressure and protecting the center are the same victory. The Ward Renewal Defeat the rusted dead and keep the Custodian safe. The skeletons come in a clatter of rust and bone: not clever, but endless, and all of them reaching for the glowing figure at the center. For every one you put down, the ritual's clock ticks a notch closer to done. But they keep clawing up out of the dirt, and the Custodian cannot defend herself. The line is yours to hold. s05-03-clatter Clatter The clatter assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal. Rusted dead claw up in a clatter of bone and metal, all of them reaching for the center. Rusted dead claw up in a clatter of bone and metal, all of them reaching for the center. Rusted dead claw up in a clatter of bone and metal, all of them reaching for the center. text-first s05-03-line Line Hold the line assets/scenes/S05-03-the-ritual-begins.png The Ritual Begins scene art for The Ward Renewal. Stand between the dead and the Custodian, split their...
- Companionmapids: MAP-S05-03 MAP-LOC-open-valetm-ritual-site MAP-LOC-goldspire-territories MAP-LOC-sablewoodtm-logistics-preserve MAP-LOC-moonglow MAP-LOC-the-miremist MAP-LOC-the-stones-of-the-vale
- Slidenumber: 67
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-C-KHARI-LATE khari-nix Khari Nix late S05-03 high optional first-use Khari, Hold the Line Finale line-holding becomes a Guardian signature beat. Khari, this is the scene for Unstoppable behavior. Who do you protect, and why now? Spotlight: Khari wiki/character/khari in-scene-prompts character defer-if-clock-

critical True True

- Spotlightsummary: 1

Export Stamp

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